

Crucially, the tie-breaker rule, previously reserved for knockout matches, was introduced to the league stage, eliminating draws and ensuring that every contest produced a definitive result.

This shift amplified the competition, turning the points table into a perpetually shifting maze. Puneri and Delhi emerged as twin leaders, finishing with identical points. The rest of the table descended into chaos, with the final week deciding even the sixth, seventh, and eighth spots. This parity meant teams could not rely on mid-table safety; every raid, every tackle, and every point difference became critical to survival.

This was a season where tactical depth trumped individual star power. The league was so tightly contested that the two finalists needed tie-breakers to decide the winner in all three meetings before the title-decider.

Crowned conqueror

Dabang Delhi's path to the championship was nothing short of a masterclass in collective effort and defensive steel. While captain Ashu Malik was the consistent raiding anchor throughout the league, his true value lay in his leadership and composure during high-pressure moments.

The defensive backbone was anchored by veteran Fazel Atrachali, the 'Sultan from Iran,' who solidified his legacy as the most successful foreign player in PKL history by clinching his third title and recording his ninth consecutive season with 50-plus tackle points. It was Fazel's crucial, final-minute ankle hold on the red-hot Aditya Shinde that secured the three-point cushion and the championship.

The title also marked a historic milestone for coach Joginder Narwal, who became the first man since Manpreet Singh to win the PKL title as both a player (Season 8 captain) and a head coach.

Paltan's heartbreak and resilience

For Puneri Paltan, Season 12 was a narrative of near-perfection tragically interrupted. Led by the



dynamic Aslam Inamdar and coached by former India captain Ajay Thakur, Paltan finished atop the league table, showcasing a squad depth and balance built for sustained excellence. Its journey to a third final appearance in four seasons reflected a culture that has consistently prioritised building a team rather than chasing star power.

Only three of the 12 teams failed to make a mark this season. Bengal Warriorz and Gujarat Giants endured forgettable campaigns. Both franchises spent over 40 per cent of their purse on single players during the auction, attempting to build teams around them. Yet even ace performers like Devank Dalal and Mohammadreza Chiyaneh Shadloui could not do it all. Poor decision-making from team management and the inability to foster balance resulted in another disappointing season for both sides.

Sultan reigns again: Fazel Atrachali, the Iranian wall, capped his ninth straight 50-tackle season by clinching the PKL crown with a game-changing ankle hold in the final. PKL MEDIA

Individual brilliance and season's best

The season also showcased several standout individual performances. Patna Pirates' raider Ayan Lohchab amassed 316 raid points, becoming only the fifth player in PKL history to breach the 300-point mark in a single season. Devank continued his fine form, finishing second in the raid charts with 271 points.

Several breakout performers emerged as well. Paltan's Aditya dazzled with his quick feet, while Bengaluru Bulls' Alireza Mirzaian displayed remarkable tenacity and skill to cement his place as the next

« This season's PKL was so competitive that Delhi and Pune needed tie-breakers to settle all three clashes before the final »